

16 — Dropshipping & Print-on-Demand

AliExpress · Printful · Shopify · Local POD · 2026

Low–medium capital · No inventory · Marketing-driven

How to sell physical products without holding stock. Covers classic dropshipping and print-on-demand (POD) models that work for Nigerians selling locally or to international buyers, realistic costs and the marketing reality.

1. What This Hustle Is

You create an online store, list products, and when a customer buys, a supplier prints or ships the item directly to them. You never touch inventory. Classic dropshipping uses general suppliers (AliExpress etc.); Print-on-Demand uses services like Printful/Printify for custom t-shirts, mugs, posters, etc. Success depends almost entirely on product selection, store quality and paid/organic traffic — not on the products themselves.

2. Realistic Path & Costs 2026

Model	Startup cost	Monthly potential (net)
Local-focused (Flutterwave/WhatsApp)	■20k–■80k	■50k–■400k
Shopify + POD (USD market)	■50k–■150k+	■100k–■1m+
Established (ads + systems)	Higher ad spend	■500k–■3m+

Net profit is typically 20–40% of revenue after product cost, platform fees and ads. Most beginners lose money on ads before finding winning products. Treat early months as testing budget, not guaranteed income.

3. Two Practical Paths for Nigerians

A. Local / African market — WhatsApp + Instagram + Flutterwave or simple store. Source from local wholesalers or Alibaba. Lower competition, naira payments, easier trust.

B. International POD / dropshipping — Shopify + Printful/Printify or AliExpress apps. Sell in USD. Higher ceiling but higher ad competition and need for strong creative.

4. Setup Sequence

1. Decide market (local vs international) and product niche.
2. Choose platform: Flutterwave Store / Instagram for local; Shopify for international.
3. Connect supplier (Printful, Printify, or tested AliExpress agents).
4. Create 8–15 product listings with clean photos and clear descriptions.
5. Set up payments (Paystack/Flutterwave local; Shopify handles international).
6. Drive traffic: organic content first, then small paid tests.

5. Key Rules

- Start with very small ad budgets and track cost-per-order ruthlessly.
- Winning products are found by testing, not guessing.
- Customer service and clear shipping expectations protect your reputation.
- POD has lower risk of supplier issues but thinner margins on some items.

6. 30-Day Starter

Days 1–10: Niche + platform + 10 products live. Days 11–20: Organic promotion + first small ad tests. Days 21–30: Analyse, kill losers, scale small winners or pivot.

7. Action Checklist

- Market and niche decided
- Store live with payment method
- Supplier connected and test order done
- 8–15 products listed with good creatives
- Tracking (pixels / basic analytics) set up
- First traffic plan (organic + small ads) ready

